

# Introduction to Sociology (Social Interaction and Social Structure)

(Ref: Richard T. Schaefer, Sociology, 10<sup>th</sup> Ed., McGraw Hills Online Resources, <http://www.mhhe.com/schaefer10>)

# Social Interaction and Social Structure

- Elements of social structure
  - Statuses
  - Social roles
  - Groups
  - Social networks
  - Social institutions

# Elements of social structure

- Statuses: Any of the full range of socially defined positions within a large group or society, from the lowest to the highest, e.g; president of Pakistan, fruit picker, father, sister, guitarist, teenager, neighbor, resident of Sindh, ...
  - Ascribed status: Assigned to a person by society without regard for the person's unique talents or characteristics, e.g; racial background, ethnicity, gender, age
    - => we can do little to change an ascribed status, but we can attempt to change the traditional constraints associated with such statuses
  - Achieved status: Achieved through our own efforts, e.g; lawyer, guitarist, social worker, convict
  - Master status: status that dominates others, e.g; Heavy weight champion / father / black American

# Elements of social structure

- Social roles: A set of expectations for people who occupy a given social position or status
  - Role conflict: Employee → Boss, male playgroup teachers, female police officer
  - Role strain: Difficulty that arises when the same social position imposes conflicting demands and expectations
  - Role exit: Process of disengagement from a role that is central to one's self identity in order to establish a new role and identity. Consists of 4 stages, i.e;
    - Doubt
    - Search for alternatives
    - Action / departure
    - Creation of a new identity

# Elements of social structure

- Groups: Any number of people with similar norms, values, and expectations who interact with one another on a regular basis
  - Social networks: A series of social relationships that links a person directly to others, and through them indirectly to still more people
  - Social networking: Involvement in social networks
  - Virtual social networks: Social networks where face-to-face involvement is not required, e.g; FOAF, Facebook, Twitter, ...
  - Modes for virtual social networking: Texting, chat, forums, video / audio conferencing...
    - Same place / same time
    - Same place / different time
    - Different place / different time
    - Different place / same time

# Elements of social structure

- Social institutions: Organized patterns of beliefs and behavior centered on basic social needs or functions
  - Essential functions (Functionalist view)
    - Replacing personnel (the family)
    - Teaching new recruits (schools or in peer groups)
    - Producing and distributing goods and services
    - Preserving order (the government)
    - Providing and maintaining a sense of purpose

# Social Structure in Global Perspective

- Social structure depends upon division of labor in a society [Durkheim, 1893]. Collective consciousness develops that emphasizes group solidarity
  - Mechanical solidarity (where there is a minimal division of labor)
    - All are performing same task
  - Organic solidarity (when society is more complex and division of labor is greater)

# Comparison of Gemeinschaft and Gesellschaft

| <b><u>Gemeinschaft</u></b>                                                                            | <b><u>Gesellschaft</u></b>                                                                             |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Typical of rural life.                                                                                | Typical of urban life.                                                                                 |
| People share a feeling of community that results from their similar backgrounds and life experiences. | People have little sense of community. Their differences appear more striking than their similarities. |
| Social interactions are intimate and familiar.                                                        | Social interactions are likely to be impersonal and task-specific.                                     |
| People maintain a spirit of cooperation and unity of will.                                            | Self-interest dominates.                                                                               |
| Tasks and personal relationships cannot be separated.                                                 | Task being performed is paramount, relationships are subordinate.                                      |
| Little emphasis on privacy.                                                                           | Privacy is valued.                                                                                     |
| Informal social control predominates.                                                                 | Formal social control is evident.                                                                      |
| People aren't very tolerant of deviance.                                                              | People are more tolerant of deviance.                                                                  |
| Emphasis is on ascribed statuses.                                                                     | Emphasis is on achieved statuses.                                                                      |
| Social change is relatively limited.                                                                  | Social change is very evident, even within a generation.                                               |



# Sociological evolution

- Hunting and gathering (beginning of human life): nomadic; reliance on readily available food and fibres
- Horticultural (about 10,000 to 12000 years ago): More settled; development of agriculture and limited technology
- Agarian (About 5000 years ago): Larger; more stable settlements; improved technology and increased crop yields
- Industrial (1760-1850): Reliance of mechanical power and new sources of energy; centralized workplaces; economic independence and formal education
- Post-industrial (1960s): Reliance on services; especially the processing and control of information; expanded middle class
- Postmodern (Later 1970s): High technology; mass consumption of consumer goods and media images; cross-cultural integration